

Advanispeak

"INDIA IS SECULAR BECAUSE it is a Hindu country. When Pakistan declared itself an Islamic state, the natural consequence should have been that India declare itself a Hindu country."

"IF ANYONE says that I am proud of being a Hindu, he is immediately branded as a communal person, but if someone says I am proud of being a Muslim, that is fine."

"IT HURT ME a lot when Manmohan Singh said my only achievement was the demolition of the Babri Masjid. When I called him the weakest prime minister, it was not personal."

"I never subscribed to Lohia's anti-English approach. 'You have a weakness for English because you studied in a Christian school,' he told me. I said, no, I am proud of my Hindi."

"THERE WAS NO RIFT between me and Vajpayee. It was all a creation of Brajesh Mishra who tried to project that the RSS was pressurising Vajpayee."

"THE GREATEST HURT in my public life was when my own party misunderstood me after my remarks on Jinnah. They should have known me better."

"I NEVER COMPARED Varun Gandhi to JP. I simply said that you invoked draconian laws against an electoral opponent thinking that he would lose the election from a prison."

"The UPA has completely disintegrated. We have lost only one ally, and that is because of its overconfidence. We are turning perceived adversity into opportunity."

"Narendra Modi is dealing either with Gujarat or with a section of the population in the country which is not apologetic about being Hindu."



SHAILESH RAVAL

IT MAY BE THE LAST CHANCE FOR ADVANI BEFORE MODI STEPS IN SOONER OR LATER

Today, he seems to realise that it is something he doesn't have to be very emphatic about. So, does it mean that he has to be less vocal about Hindutva in order to be the moderniser? Those who have been let down by this makeover ask: Look at Modi, who has struck a fine balance between his modernisation agenda and the core ideology of the Sangh Parivar. Advani is aware of this perception. "I'm dealing with it. I'm trying to communicate in a language that is acceptable to the whole country. Narendra Modi is dealing either with Gujarat or with a section of the population in the country which is not apologetic about being Hindu." That said, he argues that "India is secular only because it is a Hindu country. When Pakistan declared itself an Islamic state, the natural consequence should have been that India declares itself a Hindu country. It did not happen. Congressmen may claim that it was because of Congress. It is not true because no one even suggested in the Constituent Assembly that we declare ourselves a Hindu state." Then where does this Ram Rajya come from? "It is a concept of an ideal kingdom and I find nothing wrong with it." Still the party and its candidate suffer from an image crisis, and maybe it is because India has not yet overcome Ayodhya. Advani is not particularly bothered about that, for his campaign is not subordinated to the party. It is sustained by an idea called Advani—a constantly evolving idea that is—and managed by the few who defy organisational hierarchy. He thinks the tide is turning. "The UPA has completely disintegrated. We have lost only one ally, and that is because of its overconfidence. We are turning the perceived adversity in Orissa into an opportunity, though we never expected Naveen Patnaik to do this." That was a loss the party—or Advani—could have avoided. And some partners like Nitish Kumar are not in awe of the NDA's prime ministerial candidate.